

The Dangers of Change Approval Processes

Module 8.2 Assignment

Nima Memarzadeh

07/09/25

Approvals for change have been, since the start of IT and then DevOps, been a mostly unquestioned defensive play for system stability, unauthorized changes and security incidents. Lately, both data and case studies are putting the latter assumption into question. Approvals, when they still happen via centralized and manual methods, can become chokepoints for operations and delivery, slow it down, and still not prevent bad things from happening. This paper takes a deep look at the danger hidden in the common approach, and offers recommendations that are data-backed, to provide a safer path.

1. Inefficiency and Bottlenecks

One of the key risks associated with the change approval model is that it introduces avoidable friction. Change Advisory Boards and other centralized control models often present a bottleneck to change instead of an opportunity for quality control. Per DORA's research on the topic, the external approval performed by a CAB negatively correlates with improved software delivery performance – it lengthens lead times, reduces deployment frequency, and has not shown to improve change fail rates (DORA, 2025). The current slow process does not improve safety or agility, nor does it prepare teams for higher-quality delivery; in fact, it hurts teams in fast-paced, multi-developer environments that need to iterate quickly.

2. False Sense of Security

A second problem with change approval processes is that they are an illusion of control over risk. A good example can be seen in the DZone article dissecting the Swedbank outage. Swedbank had change control processes that were clearly not adhered to in this case because a major system change was pushed into production, triggering a huge outage and a fine of \$85 million. Not only did this cause disruption to thousands of customers, but it also triggered a fine for Swedbank by regulators (Long, 2023). In other words, despite change control processes, Swedbank

management appears to have pushed this through without the appropriate approvals. The moral of the story is that if you do not actively manage and audit your change approval process, then it provides no control over changes introduced to the system. But what if your process is bulletproof (or you think it is)? Even if you follow your change control process to the letter, the more serious problem is that this is where your high-risk changes could get missed because manual approvals do not have to be technically sound.

3. Overhead Without Risk Reduction

The requirement that all change requests go through the same approval funnel creates issues of its own. Approving changes through a single funnel results in undue time spent on low-risk changes while also distracting attention from changes that are actually risky. TeamDynamix recommends a risk based tiered approval system in which changes are classified as low, medium or high risk, each with a different level of review path (TeamDynamix, n.d.). Unfortunately, most organizations fail to use this level of sophistication and adopt a one-size-fits-all approach. This approach leads to overburdened CABs and diluted reviews.

4. Legacy Systems and Cultural Resistance

Legacy infrastructure often carries with it legacy change approval norms. Fear of fines or audits in heavily regulated industries like banking might encourage organisations to do more paperwork, but not be technically excellent. For example, the DZone summary of Accelerate is direct in saying external approvals “lower your deployment frequency with no demonstrable gain in stability” (Long, 2023). In the above, we see a culture that prizes conforming to processes over delivering results.

5. Lack of Automation and Observability

Modern IT environments require tools and processes that are fast, observable, and integrated.

The CMW Lab article emphasizes that outdated, manual approval systems introduce time waste, rigidity, and a higher likelihood of human error (CMW Lab, 2025). Automated workflows, combined with audit trails and integrated monitoring, provide a much more resilient framework. By embracing automation, organizations reduce the risk of undocumented changes and ensure traceability without obstructing delivery speed.

Conclusion

Approvals are meant to reduce IT risk but it's becoming clear that they don't. Manual, centralized approvals are not inherently safe, they just make us feel safe. Instead, we should shift to dev-led peer reviews, automation, observability, and risk-based decision frameworks that keep us agile and compliant while actually reducing risk, not just the perception of it. It's not about approving change, it's how, when and why we approve that's the real risk.

References

- CMW Lab. (2025, April 3). *What is Approval Management? Benefits, Challenges, and the Future of Automated Approval Systems in 2025*. Retrieved from <https://www.cmwlab.com/blog/approval-management-benefits-hidden-dangers/>
- DORA. (2025). *Streamlining Change Approval*. Google Cloud DevOps Research and Assessment. Retrieved from <https://dora.dev/capabilities/streamlining-change-approval/>
- Long, M. (2023, May 18). *Change Control Doesn't Work: When Regulated DevOps Goes Wrong*. DZone. Retrieved from <https://dzone.com/articles/change-control-doesnt-work>
- TeamDynamix. (n.d.). *A Risk-Based Approach to Change Review and Approval*. Retrieved from <https://solutions.teamdynamix.com/TDClient/1965/Portal/KB/ArticleDet?ID=17442>